

Onychoprion fuscatus

Sooty tern



Length 14–18 in (35–45 cm)
Weight 5–9 oz (150–250 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location Worldwide, in tropical seas



This wide-ranging, tropical tern has white undersides, but is almost completely brownish black above. A bird of the open ocean, it is often seen in large flocks, hundreds of miles from land. Unlike many of its relatives, it does not plunge-dive for its food; instead, it swoops down close to the water, snapping up fish and other small animals near the surface, rarely getting wet. Sooty terns nest in remote islands throughout the tropics, often in enormous, noisy colonies.



Larosterna inca

Inca tern



Length 15½–16½ in (39–42 cm)
Weight 6–7 oz (175–200 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened

Location W. South America



white "moustache" with yellow patch



Some terns can be difficult to tell apart, but this South American species is instantly recognizable by its slate-gray color and its remarkable white "moustache" plumes, which trail from its cheeks for 2 in (5 cm) or more. This bird occurs in the Humboldt Current region, feeding on the abundant small anchovies found in the nutrient-rich water. Large numbers of Inca terns congregate over feeding sea lions and humpback whales, diving for fish scraps left by these animals.

Rynchops flavirostris

African skimmer

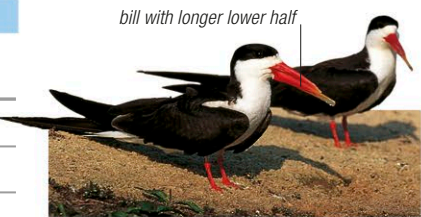


Length 14–16½ in (36–42 cm)
Weight 3½–7 oz (100–200 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened

Location Africa



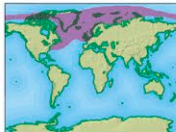
Skimmers are similar to terns in shape and general coloration, but their bill structure is unique, with the lower half much longer than the upper half, and flattened sideways rather



like scissor blades. There are 3 species, and they all feed by flying low over water, plowing the surface with the lower "blade" and snapping the bill shut when it touches a fish. The birds feed mostly at dawn and dusk. This species, like the other 2 skimmers, is black with a white underside, and its feet, legs, and bill are bright orange-red.

Alle alle

Little auk



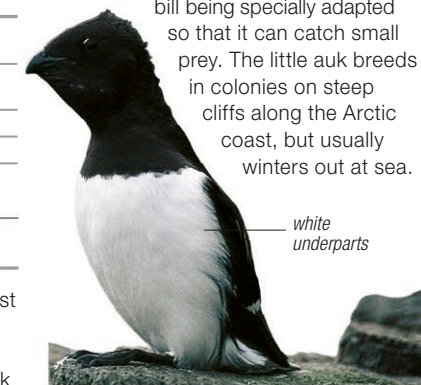
Length 7½–9 in (19–23 cm)
Weight 5–6 oz (150–175 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location Circumpolar around Arctic



Also known as the dovekie, the smallest auk in the Atlantic is a black and white bird with a short bill and an upright posture. Like other members of the auk

family, it is a pursuit diver, using its stubby wings like flippers to speed after its prey. It feeds mainly on plankton, its bill being specially adapted so that it can catch small prey. The little auk breeds in colonies on steep cliffs along the Arctic coast, but usually winters out at sea.



white underparts

Aethia pusilla

Least auklet

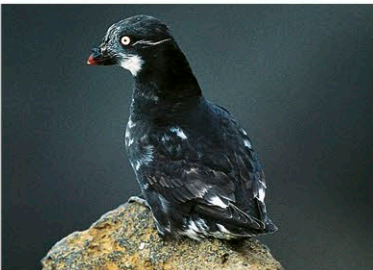


Length 6 in (15 cm)
Weight 3 oz (85 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

Location North Pacific, Arctic Ocean



The smallest of all auk species, the least auklet is the same length as a house sparrow, although its body is more heavysset. Breeding colonies may contain as many as one million birds, which set off in insectlike swarms to feed. Plankton is its only food—mainly copepods but also young crustaceans and fish larvae; the bird dives from the surface and swims through the water to find the drifting schools. It lays just one egg a year, in a crack or crevice on bare rock.



Fratercula arctica

Atlantic puffin

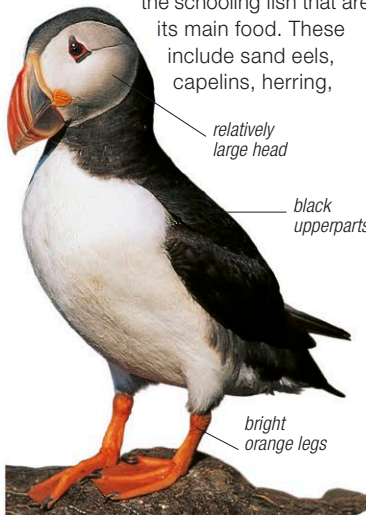


Length 11–12 in (28–30 cm)
Weight 14 oz (400 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Vulnerable

Location North Atlantic, Arctic Ocean



The puffin is the most colorful auk in the North Atlantic, with a multicolored bill and bright orange legs and feet. It sometimes dives to 200 ft (60 m) to find the schooling fish that are its main food. These include sand eels, capelins, herring,



relatively large head

black upperparts

bright orange legs

PUFFIN SOCIETY



Like most members of the auk family, the Atlantic puffin is a highly social species, nesting in colonies on rocky coasts and offshore islands. On land, puffins stand in groups, but when feeding, they gather in "rafts" out to sea. Feeding areas are usually within 6 miles (10 km) of a colony.

and sprats, which are supplemented by animal plankton in winter. When nesting, the puffin digs a burrow ¾ ft (1 m) or more deep in the ground; the burrow is often lined with feathers and plant matter. Both parents incubate the solitary egg and rear the young, carrying many small fish, packed crosswise into their bills, back to the burrow for it to eat.

BREEDING COLORS

During the breeding season, the Atlantic puffin's triangular bill is red, yellow, and blue. It fades in late summer when its outer scales are shed.

Uria aalge

Common murre



Length 15½–16½ in (39–42 cm)
Weight 30–39 oz (850–1,100 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern

Location North Atlantic, North Pacific



A relatively large, blackish brown and white auk, the common murre is gregarious, and often forms dense breeding colonies. Each pair produces a solitary egg, laid directly on the rock. The egg is sharply pointed so that it rolls around in a circle if disturbed, rather than falling off the nesting ledge. The chick leaves the ledge when about 3 weeks old and completes its development at sea.



upright posture

black feet